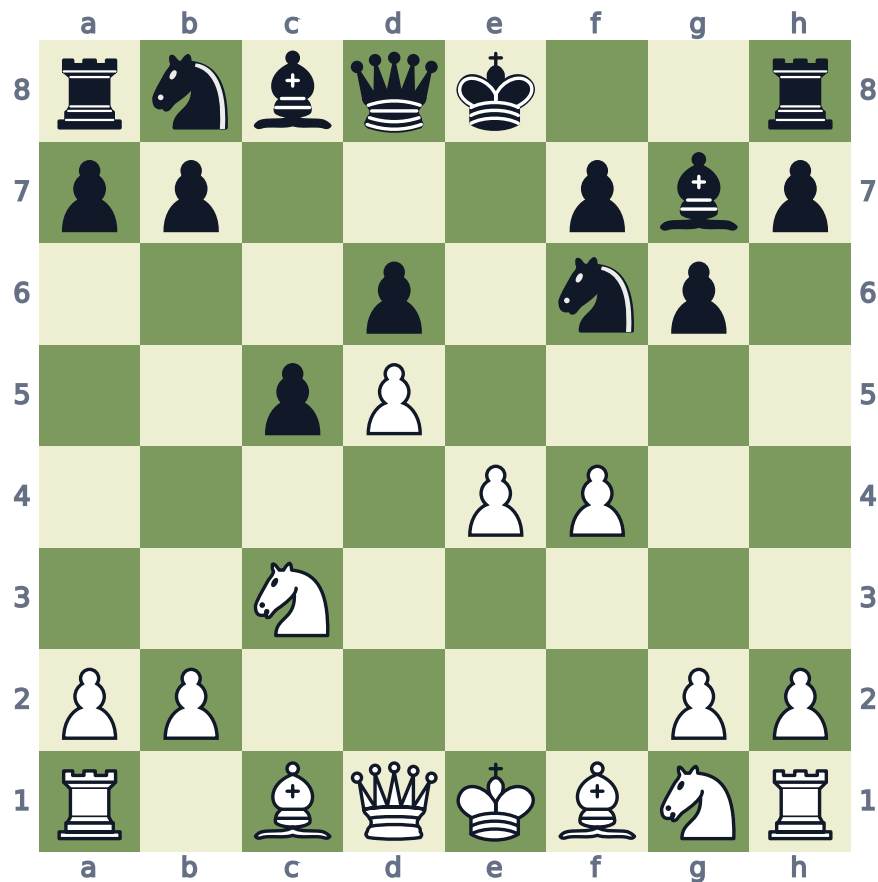


Benoni and Benko Repertoire

Space versus counterplay, e4-f4, the ...b5 break, and queenside pressure



Convert central space into active play while respecting the dynamic counterplay Black receives in Benoni and Benko structures.

8 learning units | diagrams | recall tests | engine-checked analysis

ORIENTATION

How to study this volume

PURPOSE

Convert central space into active play while respecting the dynamic counterplay Black receives in Benoni and Benko structures.

THE TRAINING LOOP

- First identify Black's defense from pawn placement and move order.
- At every diagram, name the center, the urgent threat, and two candidate moves.
- Hide the recall answer until you have spoken the move and its purpose.
- Replay each line from both sides in Fritz or another board program.
- Review misses after 1, 3, 7, 14, 30, and 60 days.
-

WHAT COMPLETE MEANS HERE

This volume contains 8 units inside a connected White repertoire. It covers the main structural and move-order decisions you need for practical play; the PGN companion makes later updating possible.

STRATEGIC FOUNDATION

Principles 1-3

PRINCIPLE 1

White's space advantage becomes real only when pieces find active squares.

PRINCIPLE 2

The e5 break can drive away the f6-knight and open attacking lanes.

PRINCIPLE 3

Black needs ...b5 or active piece pressure before the space disadvantage becomes permanent.

VERIFICATION QUESTION

What would have to be true for one of these principles to be wrong in the current position? Check forcing moves before applying a strategic rule.

STRATEGIC FOUNDATION

Principles 4-6

PRINCIPLE 4

In the Benko, the pawn buys files and diagonals rather than a quick tactic.

PRINCIPLE 5

A declined Benko reduces pressure but concedes some central choices.

PRINCIPLE 6

Count tempi before launching f4-f5 or a queenside pawn expansion.

VERIFICATION QUESTION

What would have to be true for one of these principles to be wrong in the current position? Check forcing moves before applying a strategic rule.

REPERTOIRE MAP

Branches 1-8

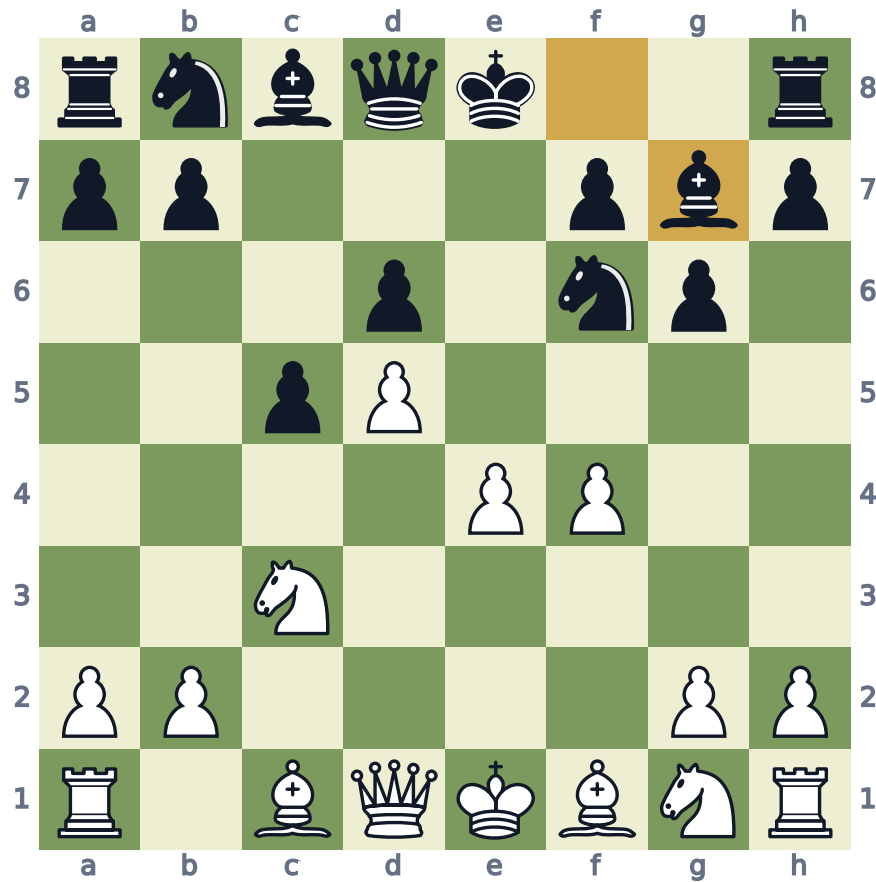
- | | | |
|----|-------------------------------|---|
| 01 | Modern Benoni core | Space gives a plan, but ...b5 gives Black activity. |
| 02 | Taimanov check | Bb5+ matters because Black's b8 knight has not developed. |
| 03 | Benoni e5 break | Prepare the break by controlling the square behind the pawn. |
| 04 | Benoni queenside break | a4 is a restraint move; play it when ...b5 is the urgent break. |
| 05 | Benko accepted | The extra pawn is real only after rooks and king find safe squares. |
| 06 | Benko declined with b6 | b6 declines the standard compensation at the cost of a fixed advanced pawn. |
| 07 | Czech Benoni | When Black blocks with ...e5, maneuvering and breaks replace immediate tactics. |
| 08 | Old Benoni | Identify the structure even when 1...c5 changes the move order. |

NAVIGATION RULE

Identify the pawn structure first, then confirm the move order. A familiar position reached by a different sequence should trigger the same plan.

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 01

Modern Benoni core



COURSE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 c5 3. d5 e6 4. Nc3 exd5 5. cxd5 d6 6. e4 g6 7. f4 Bg7

WHITE'S IDEA

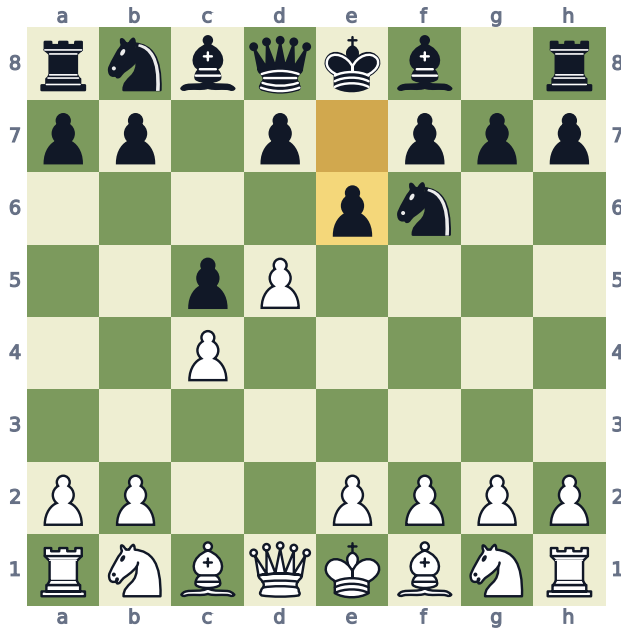
Use e4-f4 and prepare e5 while Black seeks queenside counterplay.

MAIN DANGER

The center can be attacked by ...Re8, ...b5, and tactics on e4.

BRANCH LOGIC 01

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

Space gives a plan, but ...b5 gives Black activity.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

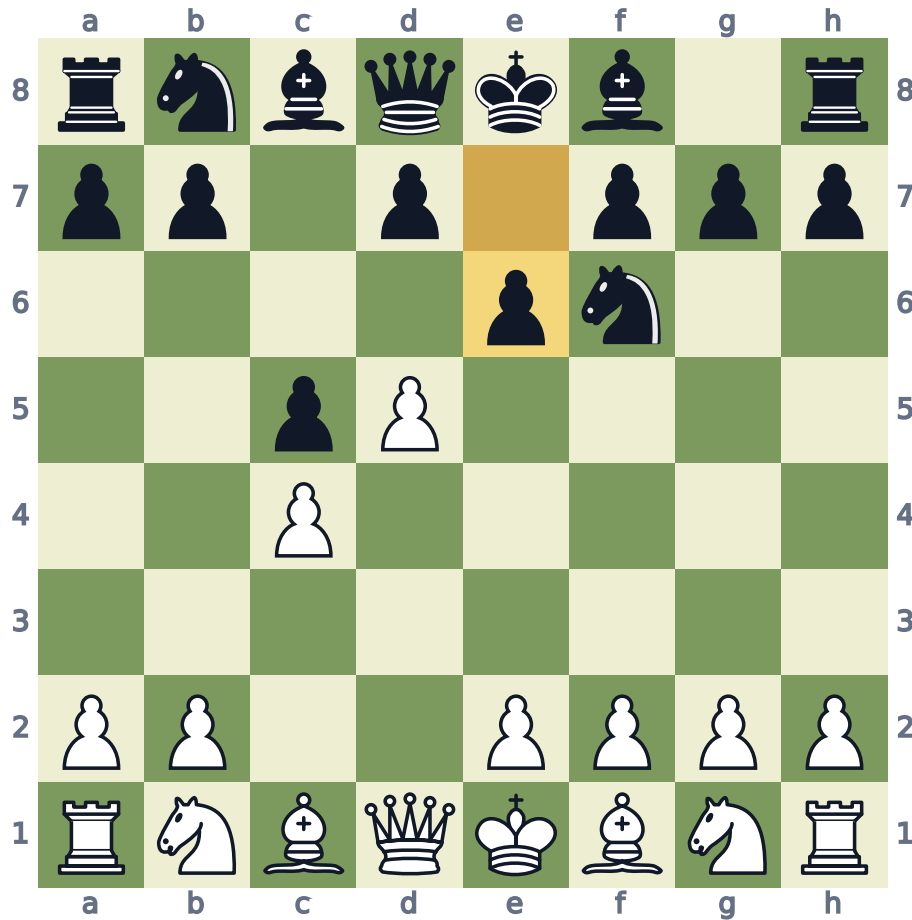
Position estimate: +0.81 for White (White is clearly better). Principal continuation: 1. Bb5+ Nfd7 2. Be2 Qh4+ 3. g3 Qe7 4. Nf3 O-O 5. O-O Na6

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 01

Modern Benoni core



YOUR TASK

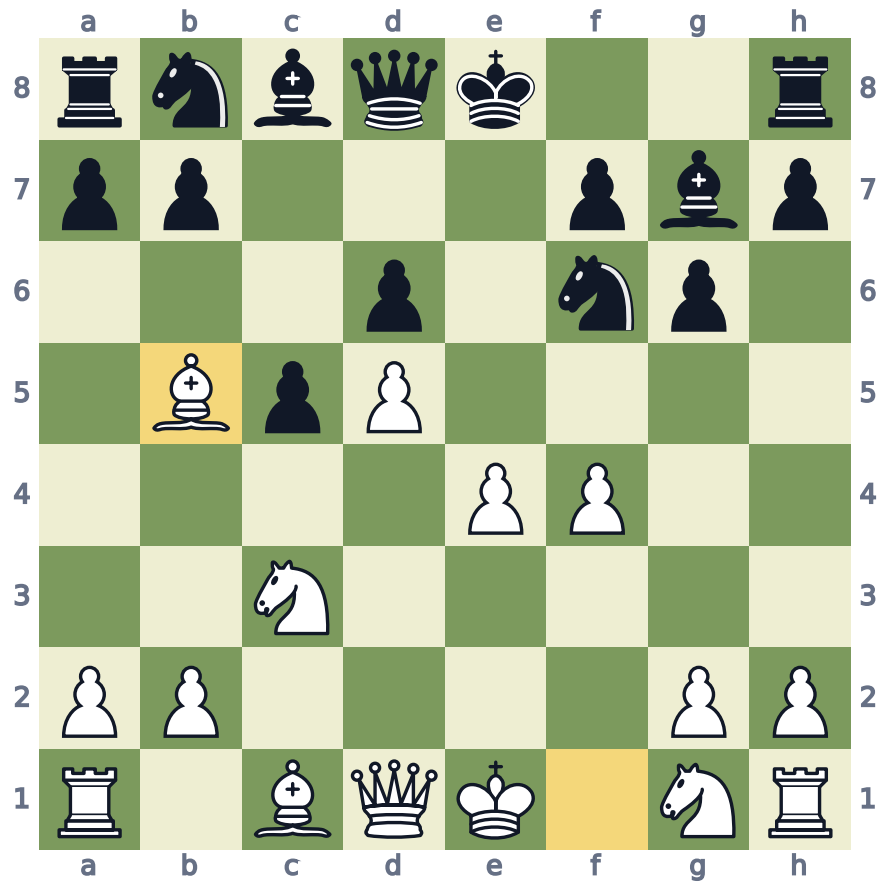
White to move. Name Black's opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give Black's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 02

Taimanov check



COURSE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 c5 3. d5 e6 4. Nc3 exd5 5. cxd5 d6 6. e4 g6 7. f4 Bg7 8. Bb5+

WHITE'S IDEA

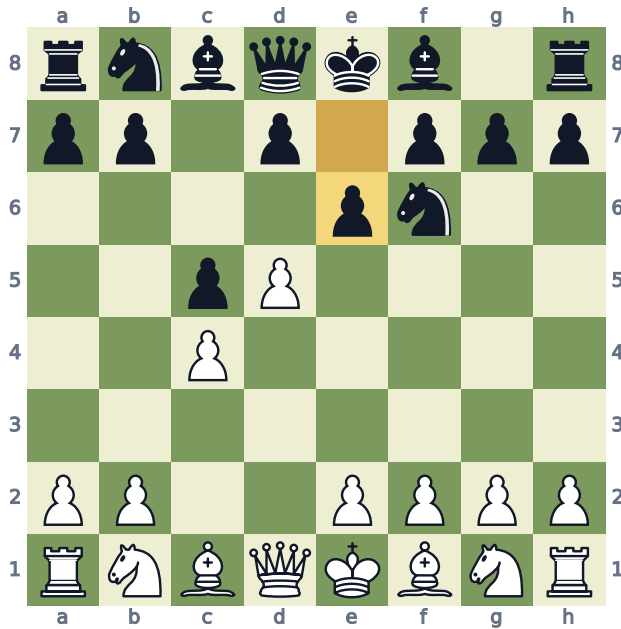
Use the check to interfere with Black's development before castling.

MAIN DANGER

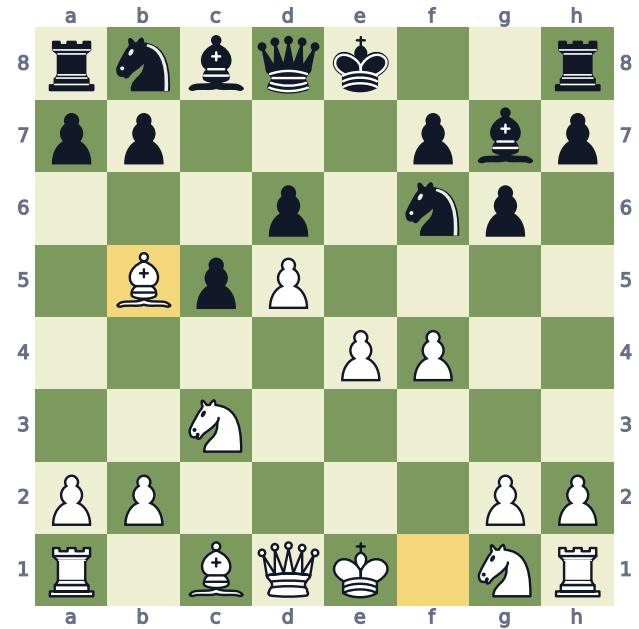
A check without a follow-up can merely improve Black's pieces.

BRANCH LOGIC 02

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

Bb5+ matters because Black's b8 knight has not developed.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

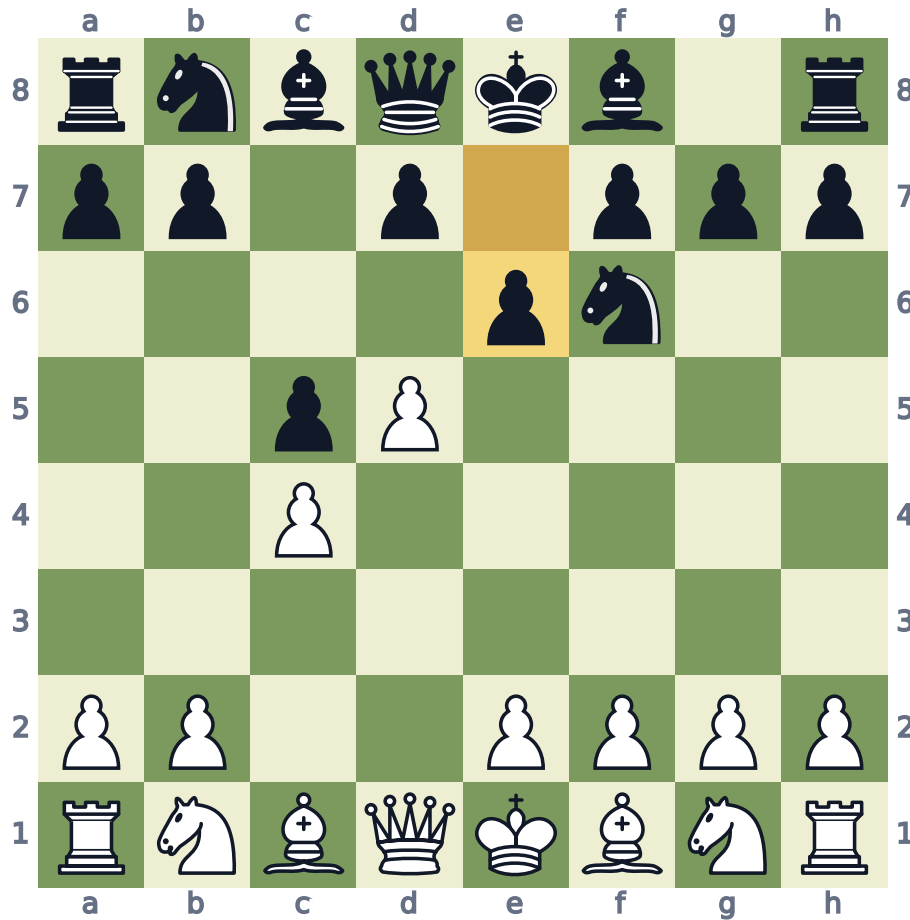
Position estimate: +0.76 for White (White is slightly better). Principal continuation: 1. Nfd7 Be2 2. Qh4+ g3 3. Qd8 Nf3 4. O-O O-O 5. Na6 g4

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 02

Taimanov check



YOUR TASK

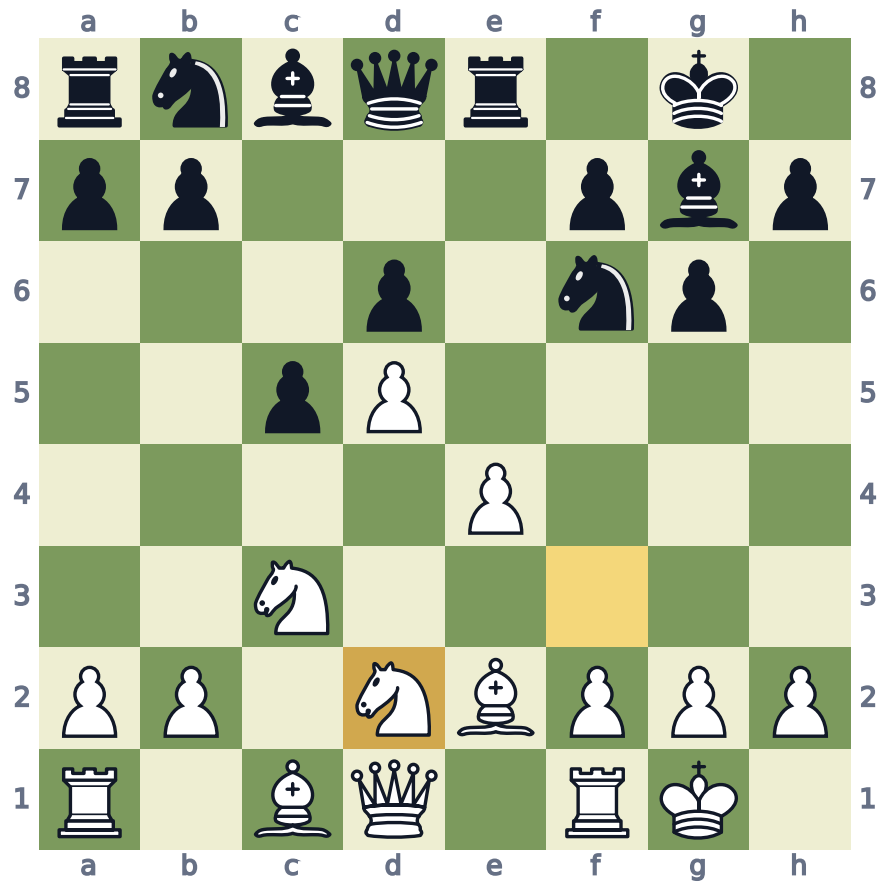
White to move. Name Black's opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give Black's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 03

Benoni e5 break



COURSE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 c5 3. d5 e6 4. Nc3 exd5 5. cxd5 d6 6. e4 g6 7. Nf3 Bg7 8. Be2 O-O 9. O-O Re8 10. Nd2

WHITE'S IDEA

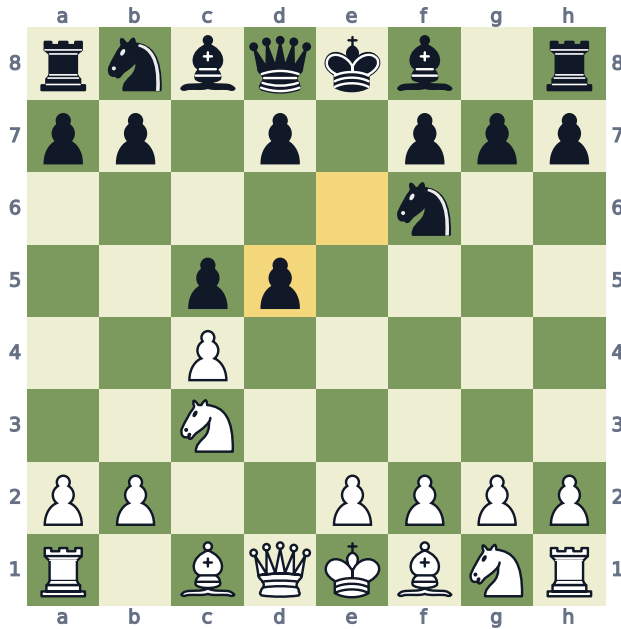
Support e4 and prepare f3 or Nc4 before driving with e5.

MAIN DANGER

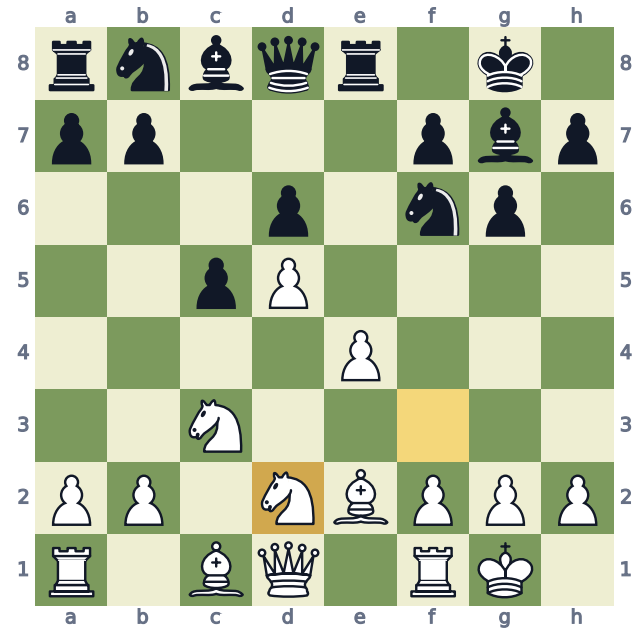
e5 can leave d5 weak if the pieces cannot follow.

BRANCH LOGIC 03

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 8 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

Prepare the break by controlling the square behind the pawn.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

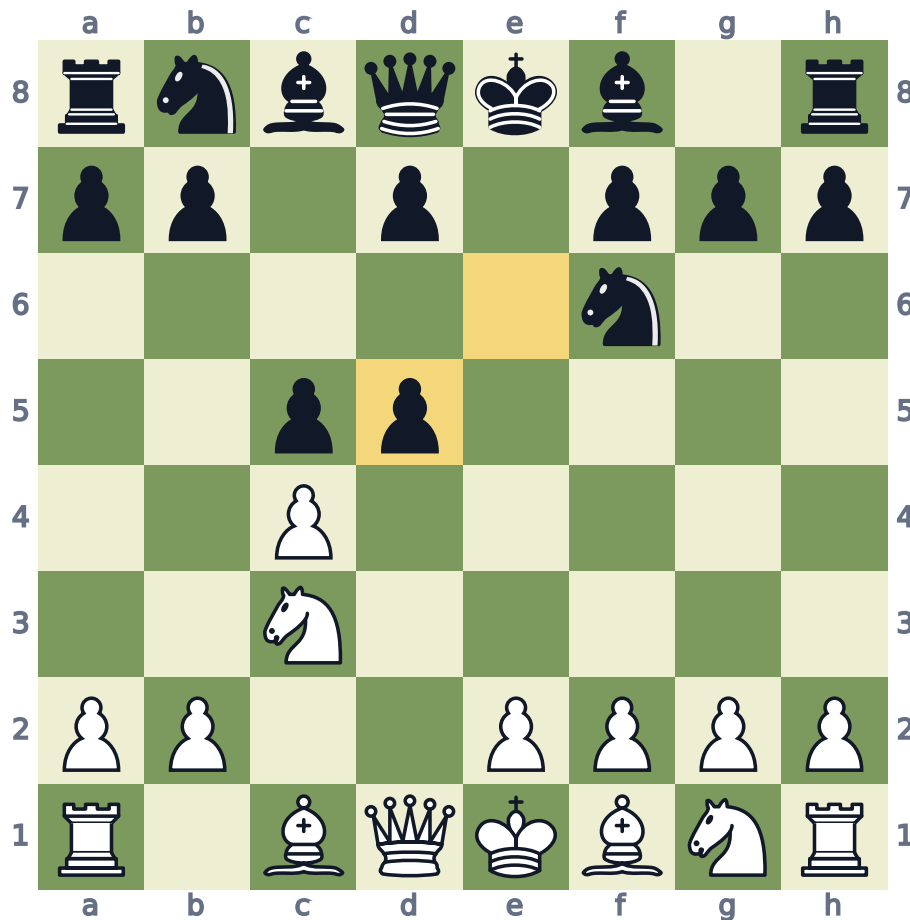
Position estimate: +0.74 for White (White is slightly better). Principal continuation: 1. Na6 f3 2. Nc7 a4 3. Nd7 Kh1 4. b6 Nb5 5. Nxb5 Bxb5

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 03

Benoni e5 break



YOUR TASK

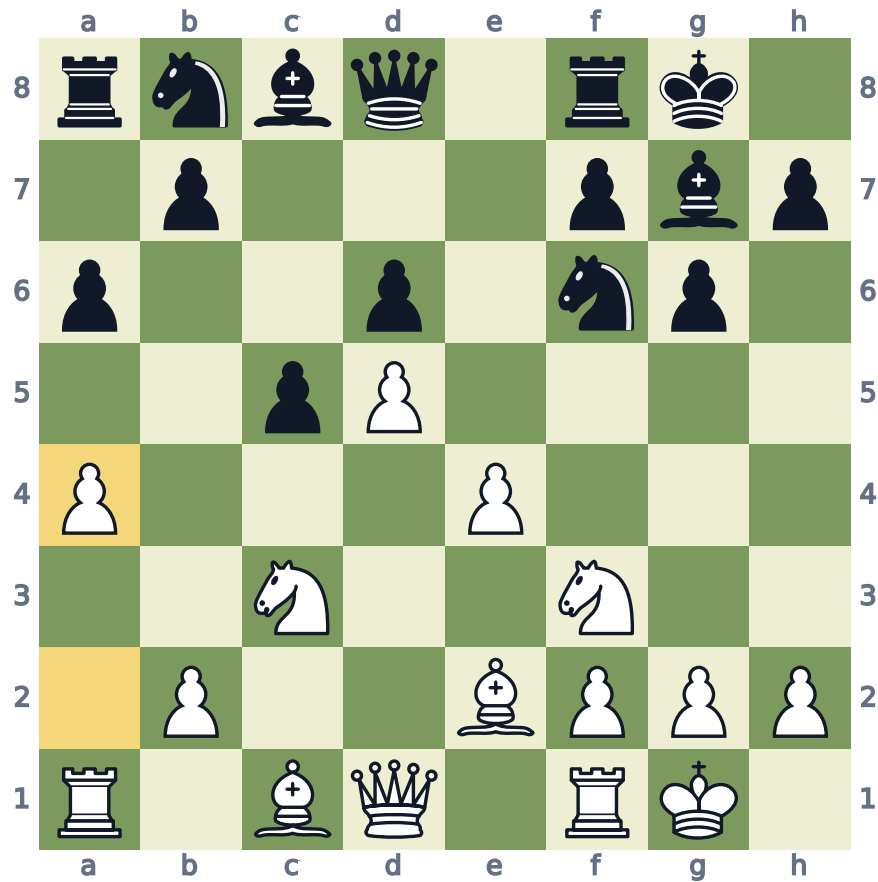
White to move. Name Black's opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give Black's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 04

Benoni queenside break



COURSE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 c5 3. d5 e6 4. Nc3 exd5 5. cxd5 d6 6. e4 g6 7. Nf3 Bg7 8. Be2 O-O 9. O-O a6 10. a4

WHITE'S IDEA

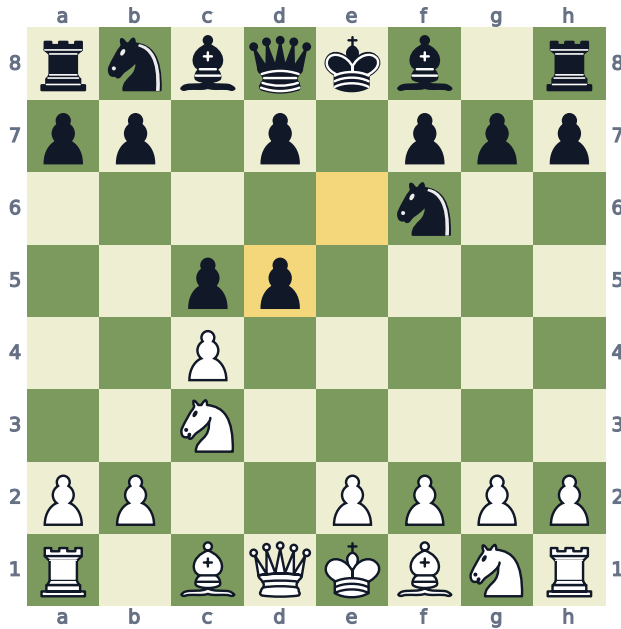
Restrict ...b5 and make Black work for queenside counterplay.

MAIN DANGER

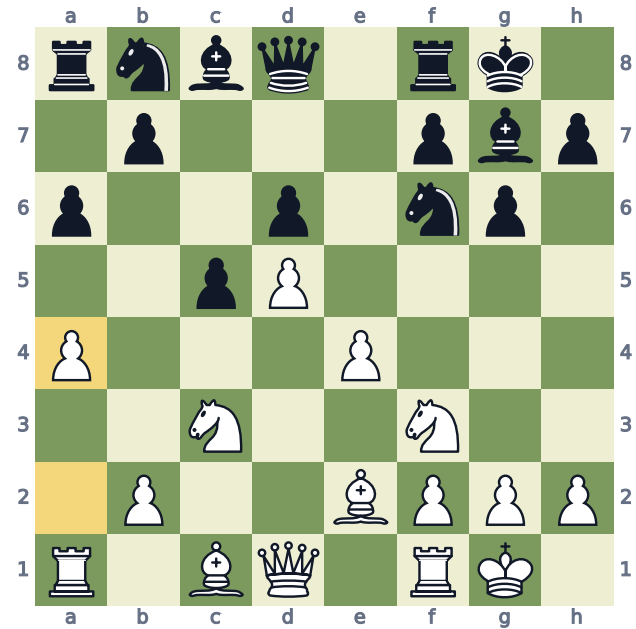
a4 creates b4 as an outpost and cannot be reversed.

BRANCH LOGIC 04

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 8 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

a4 is a restraint move; play it when ...b5 is the urgent break.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

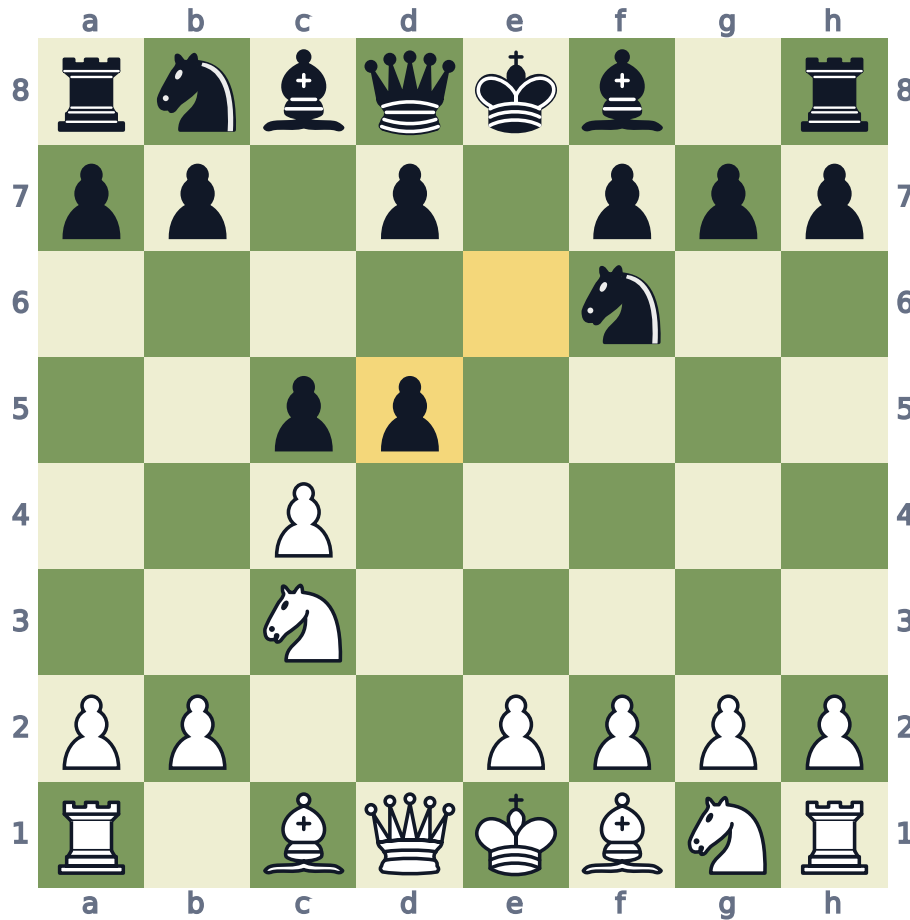
Position estimate: +0.63 for White (White is slightly better). Principal continuation: 1. Bg4 Nd2 2. Bxe2 Qxe2 3. Nbd7 a5 4. b6 axb6 5. Nxb6 Rxa6

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 04

Benoni queenside break



YOUR TASK

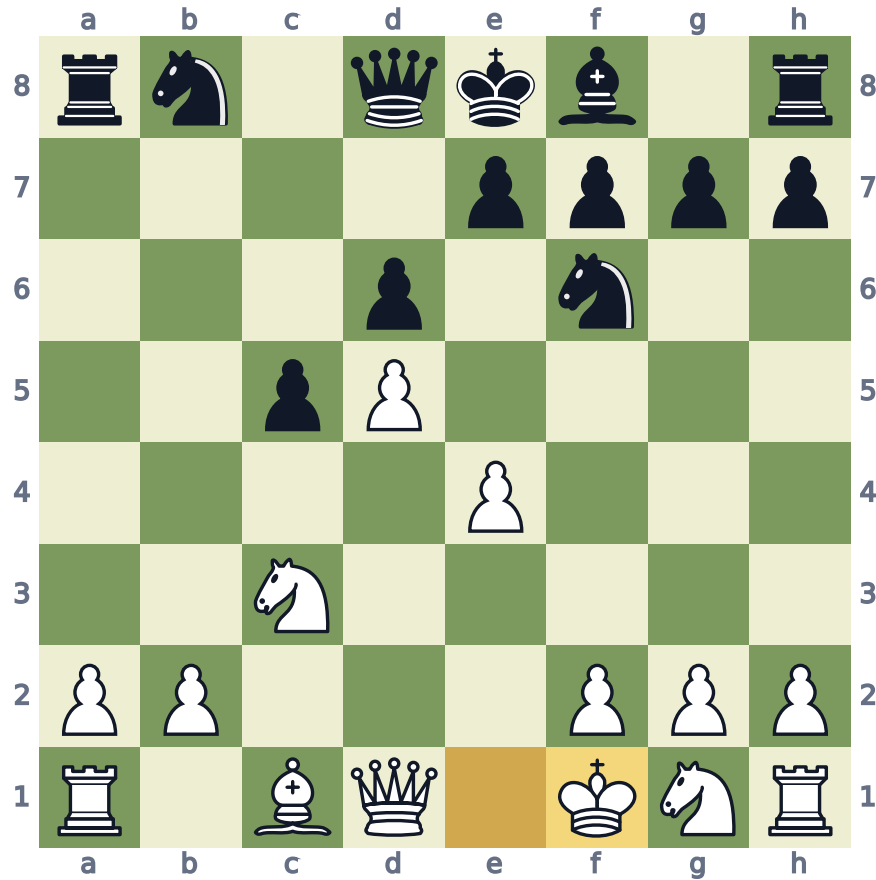
White to move. Name Black's opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give Black's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 05

Benko accepted



COURSE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 c5 3. d5 b5 4. cxb5 a6 5. bxa6 Bxa6 6. Nc3 d6 7. e4 Bxf1 8. Kxf1

WHITE'S IDEA

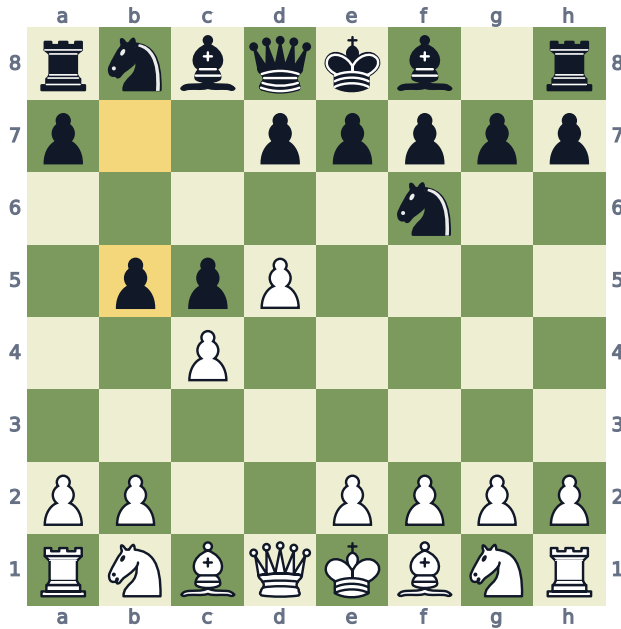
Consolidate the extra pawn while neutralizing files and the g7 bishop.

MAIN DANGER

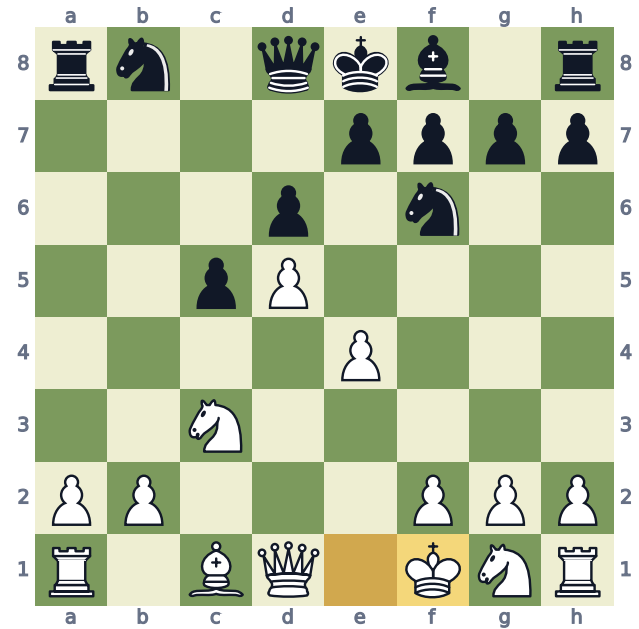
The king and queenside can remain awkward for many moves.

BRANCH LOGIC 05

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

The extra pawn is real only after rooks and king find safe squares.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

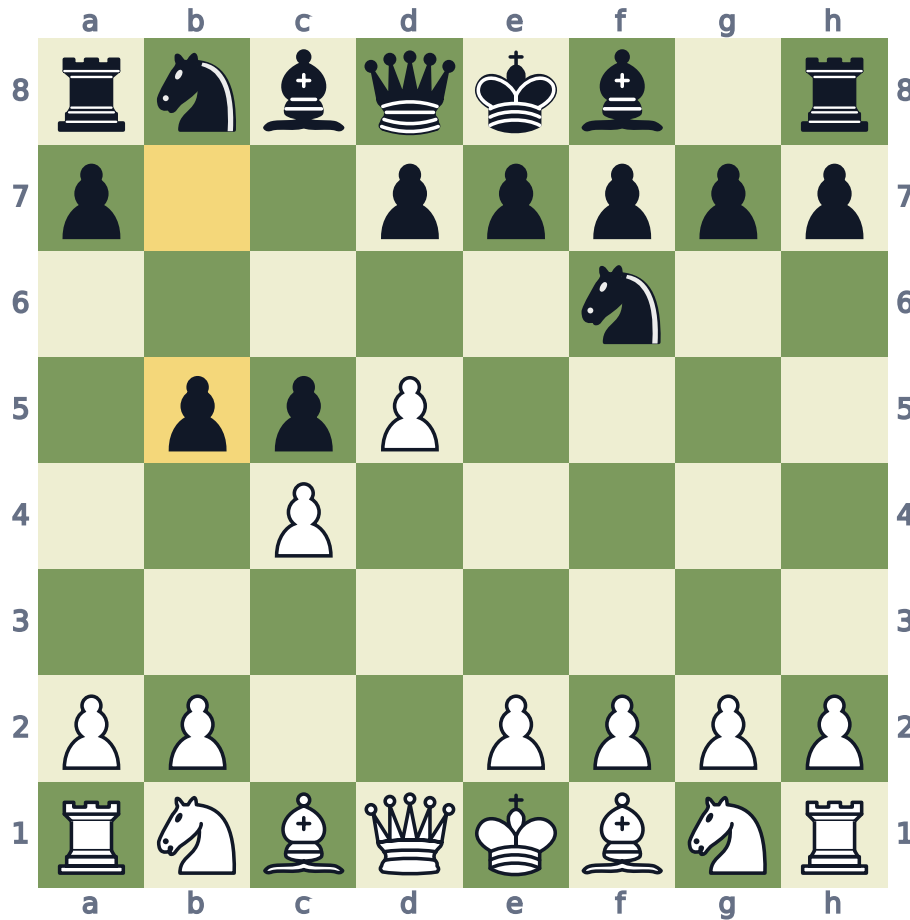
Position estimate: +0.83 for White (White is clearly better). Principal continuation: 1. g6 g3 2. Bg7 Nf3 3. O-O Kg2 4. Nbd7 a4 5. Ng4 h3

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 05

Benko accepted



YOUR TASK

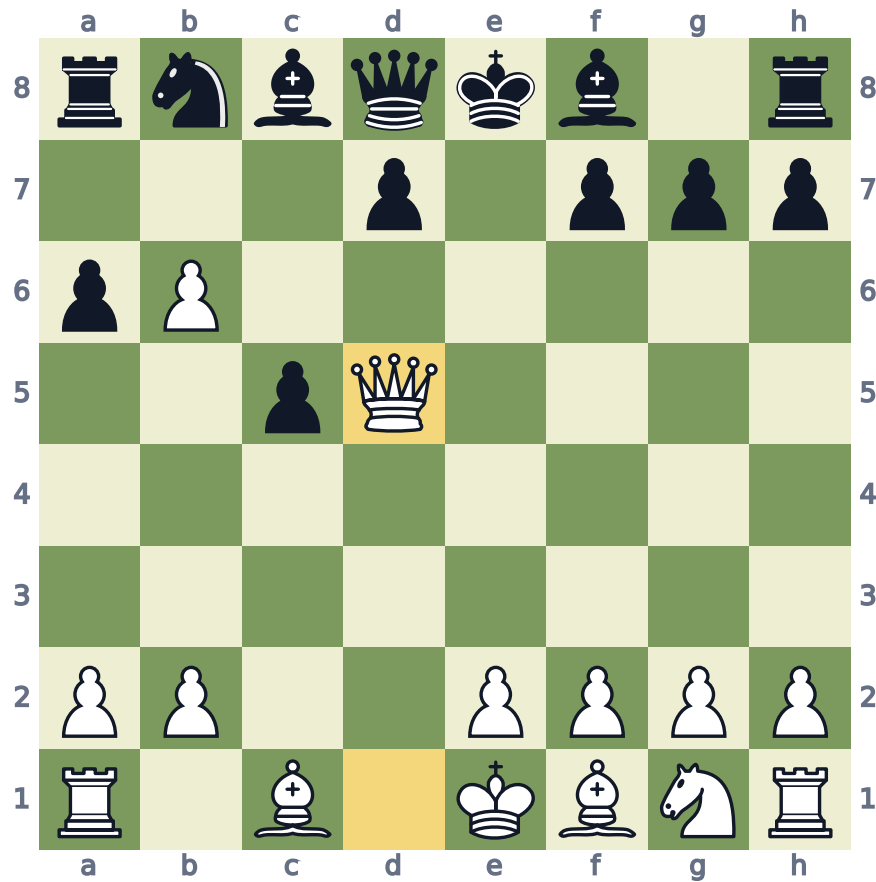
White to move. Name Black's opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give Black's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 06

Benko declined with b6



COURSE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 c5 3. d5 b5 4. cxb5 a6 5. b6 e6 6. Nc3 exd5 7. Nxd5 Nxd5 8. Qxd5

WHITE'S IDEA

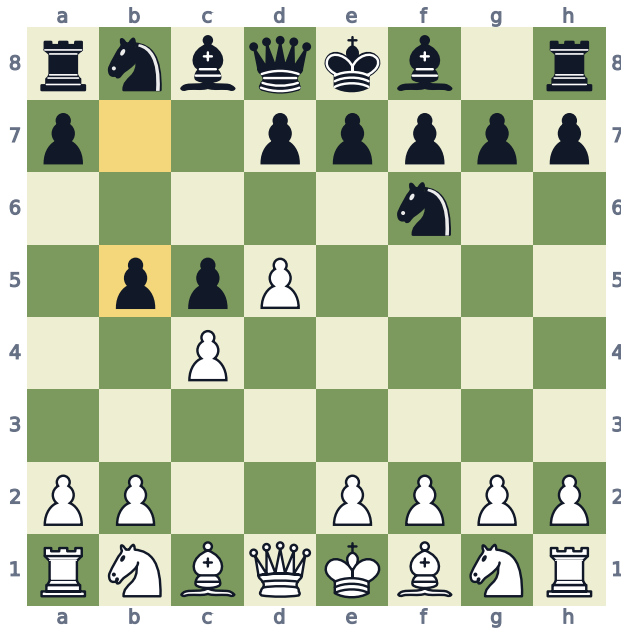
Avoid the full a- and b-file pressure and use the advanced b6 pawn as a cramping wedge.

MAIN DANGER

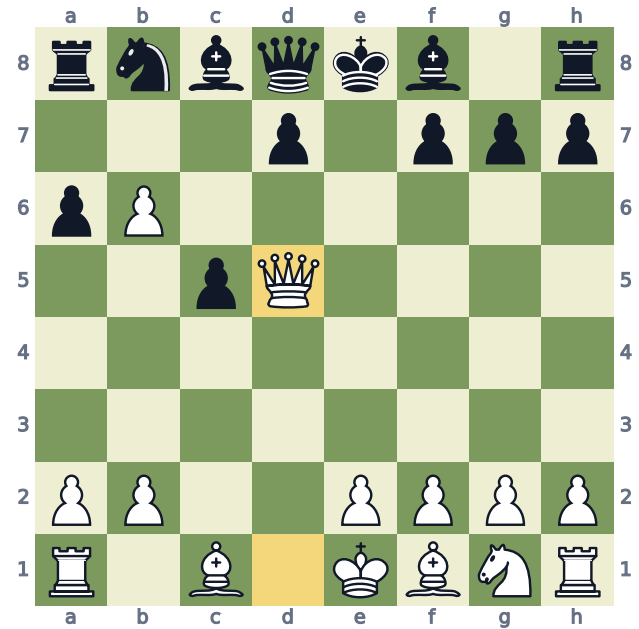
The pawn can become weak and Black may gain central tempi.

BRANCH LOGIC 06

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

b6 declines the standard compensation at the cost of a fixed advanced pawn.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

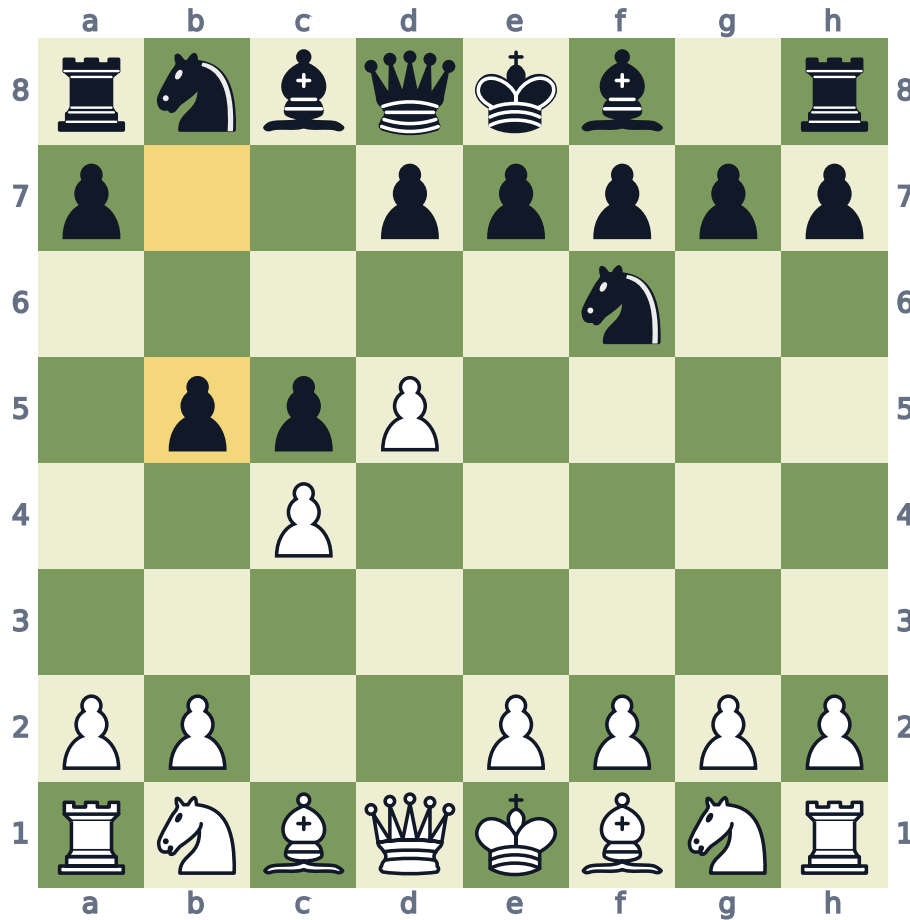
Position estimate: +0.48 for White (White is slightly better). Principal continuation: 1. Nc6 Nf3 2. Be7 Ne5 3. O-O Nc4 4. Rb8

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 06

Benko declined with b6



YOUR TASK

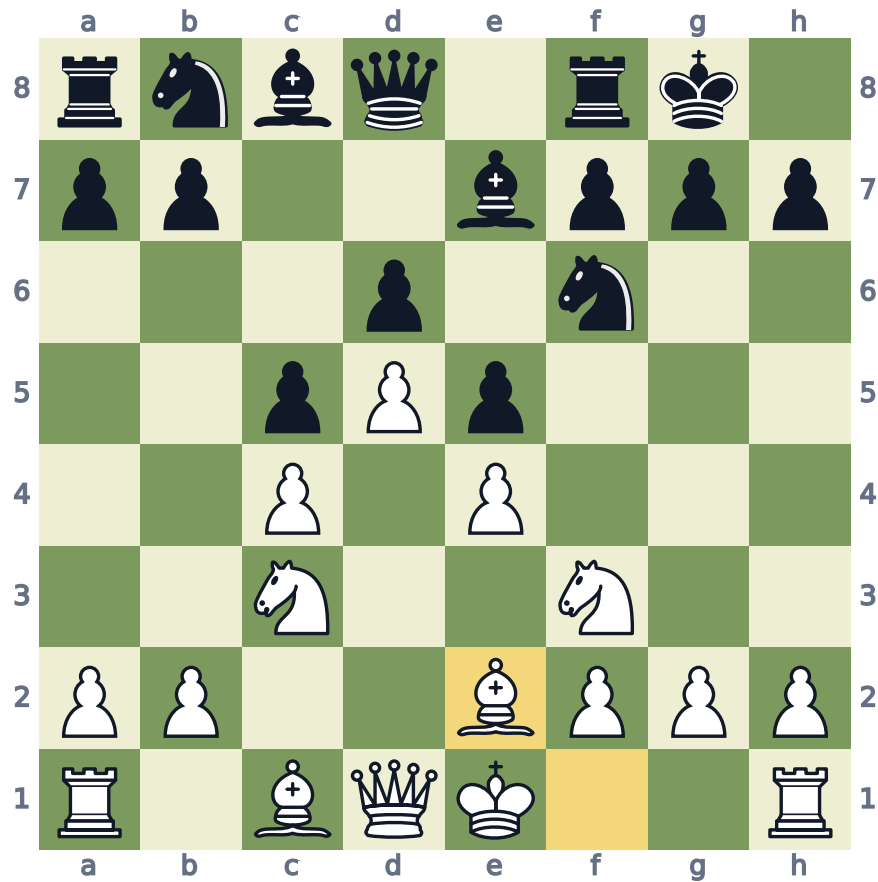
White to move. Name Black's opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give Black's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 07

Czech Benoni



COURSE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 c5 3. d5 e5 4. Nc3 d6 5. e4 Be7 6. Nf3 O-O 7. Be2

WHITE'S IDEA

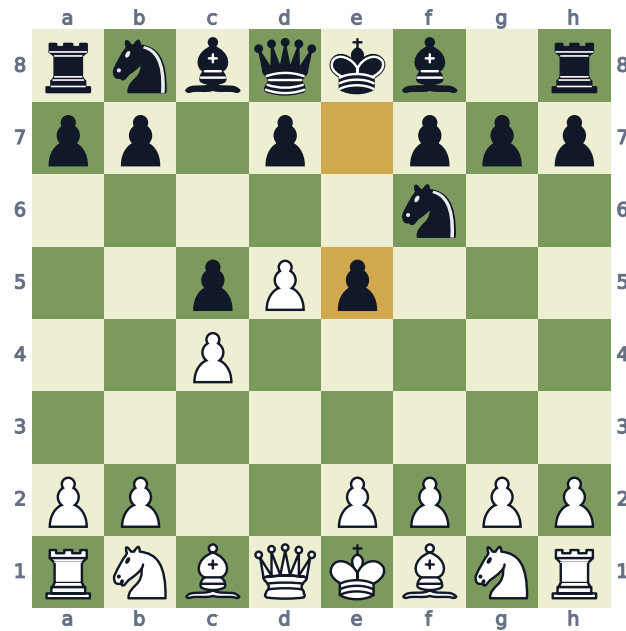
Use the space advantage and prepare a pawn break on either wing.

MAIN DANGER

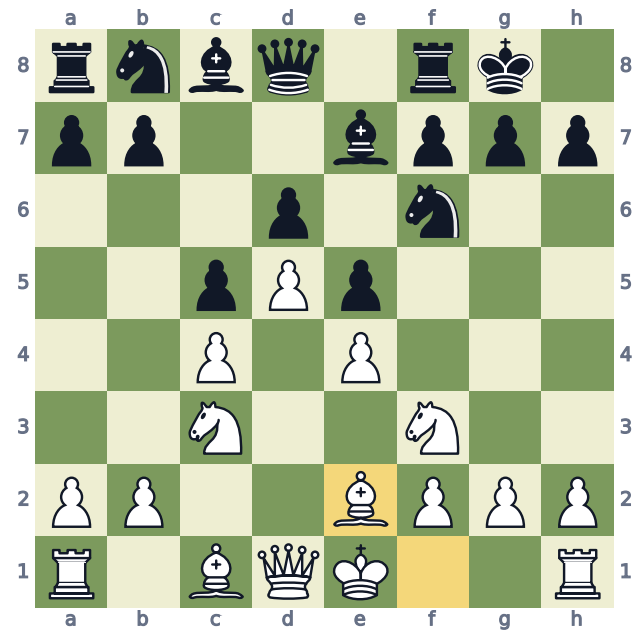
The locked center encourages overexpansion without development.

BRANCH LOGIC 07

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

When Black blocks with ...e5, maneuvering and breaks replace immediate tactics.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

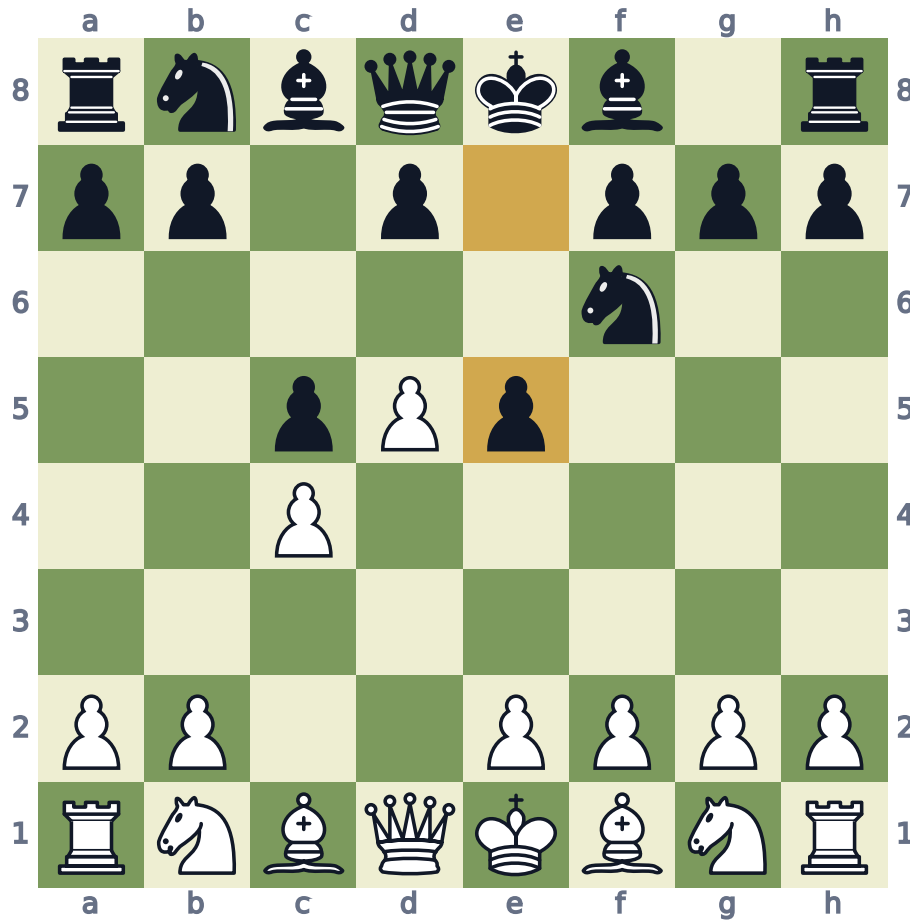
Position estimate: +1.15 for White (White is clearly better). Principal continuation: 1. h6 h3 2. Nh7 Bd3 3. a6 a4 4. b6 Bb1

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 07

Czech Benoni



YOUR TASK

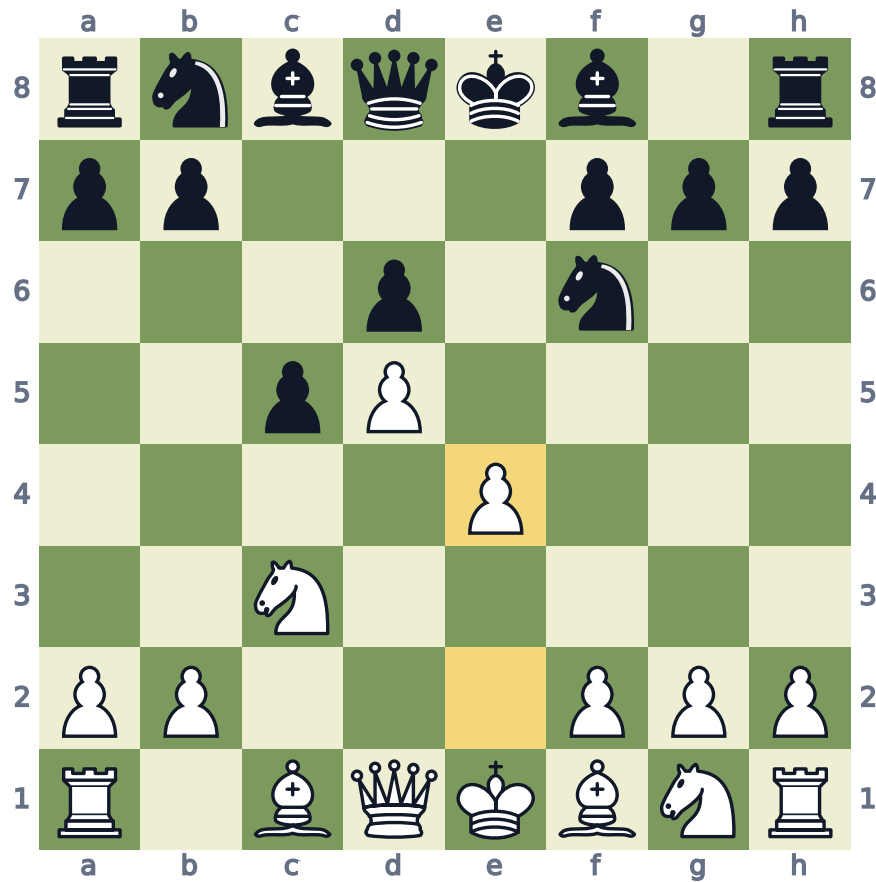
White to move. Name Black's opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give Black's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 08

Old Benoni



COURSE LINE

1. d4 c5 2. d5 Nf6 3. c4 e6 4. Nc3 exd5 5. cxd5 d6 6. e4

WHITE'S IDEA

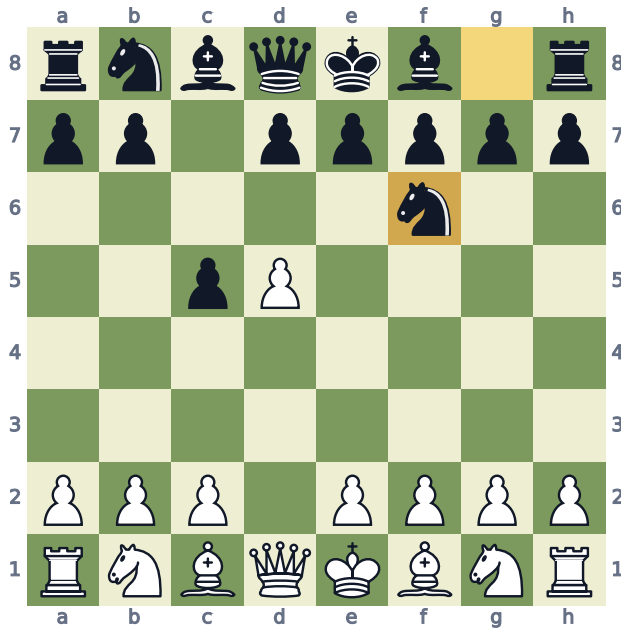
Transpose into a favorable Benoni setup with the center already secured.

MAIN DANGER

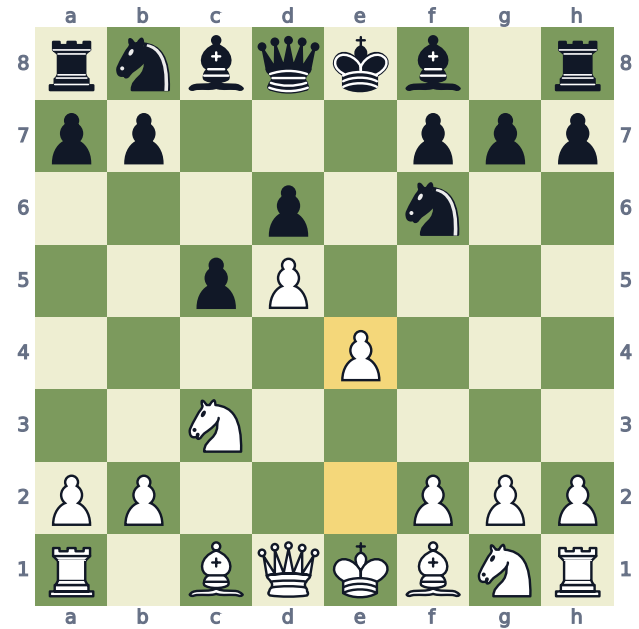
Move-order complacency can allow ...b5 under good conditions.

BRANCH LOGIC 08

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 4 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

Identify the structure even when 1...c5 changes the move order.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

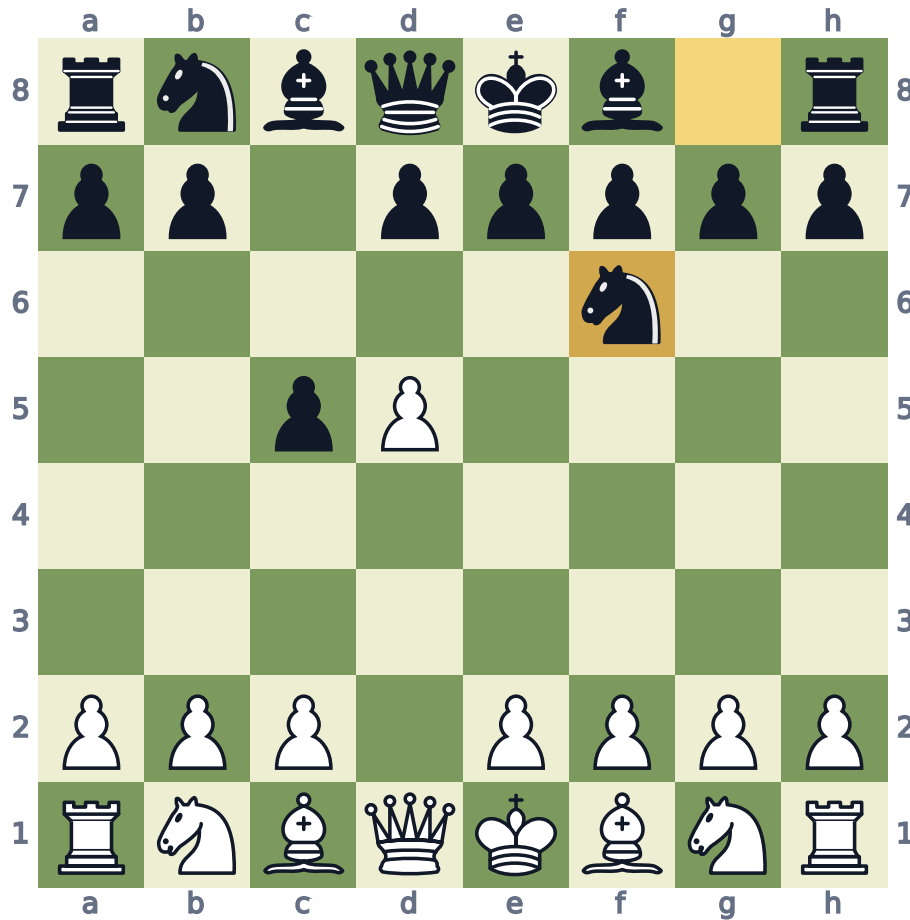
Position estimate: +0.84 for White (White is clearly better). Principal continuation: 1. g6 f4 2. Bg7 Bb5+ 3. Nfd7 Be2 4. O-O Nf3 5. Re8 O-O

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 08

Old Benoni



YOUR TASK

White to move. Name Black's opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give Black's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

ANSWER SECTION

Recall solutions begin here

PROTECT THE TRAINING EFFECT

Do not read a solution until you have committed to a move and purpose. A matching move without the correct reason earns partial credit. If the course move is not the engine's first choice, compare plans rather than treating the engine as a memorization oracle.

ERROR LABELS

M = move-order memory | T = tactical oversight | P = plan misunderstanding | V = visualization | C = calculation | R = rushed recognition

REPAIR RULE

Every miss must produce a question you can use in future games. Example: 'When Black supports d5 with c6, which pawn break or recovery method does my repertoire use?'

SOLUTIONS

Answers 1-3

01. MODERN BENONI CORE

Course move: Nc3. Purpose: Use e4-f4 and prepare e5 while Black seeks queenside counterplay. Engine comparison: 1. Nc3 g6 2. e4 d6 3. h3 Bg7 4. Bd3 (+0.95 for White (White is clearly better)). Warning: The center can be attacked by ...Re8, ...b5, and tactics on e4.

02. TAIMANOV CHECK

Course move: Nc3. Purpose: Use the check to interfere with Black's development before castling. Engine comparison: 1. Nc3 g6 2. e4 d6 3. h3 Bg7 4. Bd3 (+0.95 for White (White is clearly better)). Warning: A check without a follow-up can merely improve Black's pieces.

03. BENONI E5 BREAK

Course move: cxd5. Purpose: Support e4 and prepare f3 or Nc4 before driving with e5. Engine comparison: 1. cxd5 d6 2. e4 g6 3. Bd3 Bg7 4. h3 O-O 5. Nf3 Re8 (+0.76 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: e5 can leave d5 weak if the pieces cannot follow.

SOLUTIONS

Answers 4-6

04. BENONI QUEENSIDE BREAK

Course move: cxd5. Purpose: Restrict ...b5 and make Black work for queenside counterplay. Engine comparison: 1. cxd5 d6 2. e4 g6 3. Bd3 Bg7 4. h3 O-O 5. Nf3 Re8 (+0.76 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: a4 creates b4 as an outpost and cannot be reversed.

05. BENKO ACCEPTED

Course move: cxb5. Purpose: Consolidate the extra pawn while neutralizing files and the g7 bishop. Engine comparison: 1. cxb5 a6 2. bxa6 e6 3. Nc3 exd5 4. Nxd5 Be7 5. Nf3 Nxd5 (+0.63 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: The king and queenside can remain awkward for many moves.

06. BENKO DECLINED WITH B6

Course move: cxb5. Purpose: Avoid the full a- and b-file pressure and use the advanced b6 pawn as a cramping wedge. Engine comparison: 1. cxb5 a6 2. bxa6 e6 3. Nc3 exd5 4. Nxd5 Be7 5. Nf3 Nxd5 (+0.63 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: The pawn can become weak and Black may gain central tempi.

SOLUTIONS

Answers 7-8

07. CZECH BENONI

Course move: Nc3. Purpose: Use the space advantage and prepare a pawn break on either wing. Engine comparison: 1. Nc3 d6 2. e4 a6 3. Qc2 Nbd7 4. Be2 h6 5. g3 b6 (+1.14 for White (White is clearly better)). Warning: The locked center encourages overexpansion without development.

08. OLD BENONI

Course move: c4. Purpose: Transpose into a favorable Benoni setup with the center already secured. Engine comparison: 1. Nc3 g6 2. e4 d6 3. h3 Bg7 4. Bd3 (+0.75 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: Move-order complacency can allow ...b5 under good conditions.

VOLUME REVIEW

Make the repertoire usable

REVIEW TASK 1

Reconstruct every branch from the first move without looking.

REVIEW TASK 2

For each branch, explain one Black plan and one White plan.

REVIEW TASK 3

Shuffle the recall positions so the chapter title cannot reveal the answer.

REVIEW TASK 4

Play each starting position against Fritz from both sides.

REVIEW TASK 5

Add mistakes from your own games to the PGN as new training positions.

REVIEW TASK 6

Retest the weakest three branches after 1, 3, 7, 14, 30, and 60 days.

GRADUATION STANDARD

Score at least 80 percent twice, one week apart, and explain every move in plain language. Then maintain the volume through your own games instead of rereading it continuously.